

Rejected. Then Approved.

Before We Start

If you're a founder or a freelancer and you've tried to get a US visa, you already know the specific kind of dread I'm talking about.

Before we start, this was me within my first four hours in the United States. I had just landed in JFK, New York City. I was feeling like the world is mine, you'd think that I'd want to see the Statue of Liberty or Times Square first but the first thing I wanted to see was where the heck did Tobey Maguire dance in *Spider-Man 3*, I had promised myself as a kid that this will be the first thing I do after reaching Manhattan.



As a founder or a freelancer, you don't have a salary slip. Or maybe you do, but you don't have an HR letter on company letterhead saying you've worked here for six years and you have ten more to go. Okay maybe you do have that as well but you don't have a manager who'll confirm you're expected back at your desk on Monday.

What you have is a business that maybe didn't exist eighteen months ago or for some even 4 months ago, an income that's different every month, and a story that doesn't fit any of the boxes on the form. And you're supposed to walk up to a window and convince a stranger, in about sixty seconds, that you'll come back to a country they have never seen, to a life they can't verify.

I failed the first time. Badly. I spent roughly ₹2 lakh across agent fees, application fees, flights, hotels, local travel and four trips to Hyderabad: two for fingerprints and two for interviews. Hiring a former visa officer privately to tell me what I was doing wrong cost more than \$500 alone. I ended up getting approved on the second attempt however. Since then I've been to the USA a lot of times, no issues, and I look forward to going more.

This document is everything that money and those two attempts bought me. It's not advice from a consultant who's read a manual. It's my actual rejection, my actual answers, what I wore, what I said, what I changed, and what the officer who used to sit on the other side of that glass told me when I paid him to be honest with me, which was tailored for my case of being a founder and taking on a few freelance projects.

A few things before you read on. I'm not a lawyer and I'm not an immigration consultant, this is my own experience, nothing more. The decision is always the officer's, and nobody can guarantee you anything; anyone who says they can is lying to you. And the single most important rule in this entire document, the one everything else sits underneath: never lie. Not about your reason, not about your plans, not about a single thing. Everything that worked for me worked *because* it was true. This isn't a guide to gaming the system. It's a guide to telling the truth well which, if you're a founder, is harder than it sounds, because our truth is genuinely complicated. This is a guide on everything I learned.

The Rejection

In August 2024 I walked into the US consulate in Hyderabad with no plan, a stack of files nobody would ever open, and a t-shirt I'd put on like it was any other day. I thought I'd be like Mark Zuckerberg if I wore a plain t-shirt because "at least I was making good money".

I'd done the whole thing myself. Booked the appointment (got it in Hyderabad), sat down with the DS-160, filled it out the way you fill out anything you assume is just paperwork. When the form asked for my company, I typed "Priyam Raj." That was it, my own name in the company field, because I didn't have an entity yet and I figured that's just what you do when the business is sole proprietorship or you just do contract work, I had just gotten Morise.ai, a SaaS I founded acquired and did some freelance on the side, doing decent revenue.

I didn't think about it for more than a few seconds. It's the kind of small thing that feels like nothing while you're doing it and looks like the whole problem in hindsight. I genuinely thought none of this should be a problem because I'm making more money than most people my age and I got humbled real quick.

Here's something nobody tells you clearly: this is two trips, not one. The first time you fly to the consulate city, it's only for fingerprints, biometrics, a few minutes, done, fly home unless your interview appointment is like on the next day, mine was like a week later and I was living in Bangalore.

The actual interview is a separate appointment, a separate flight. So by the time I was standing at that window I'd already made the trip twice, already spent on flights and a hotel, already put more planning into the logistics of getting there than into the sixty seconds that actually decide everything. I made the effort backwards. I'd optimized the easy part and walked into the hard part cold.

And I was nervous in a way I wasn't prepared for. Not nervous like an exam, nervous like my body knew something my head hadn't admitted, which was that I had nothing solid to say. The officer looked at me and asked where I work. Simple question. And I just... shrank.

I mumbled something about running my own business. "I'm an Entrepreneur". It came out apologetic, like I wasn't sure I was allowed to call it that. The officer kept typing something and never made eye contact, making me even more nervous.

In my head I'd built up this idea that he would ask me my story, that there'd be a back-and-forth, that I'd get a chance to explain who I was and what I was building and why any of it made sense. That is not what happens. There is a line of people behind you stretching back to the door, and the officer has maybe a minute for each one. They are not going to excavate your story for you. They are not curious. If you do not say the thing, the thing does not exist in that room.

That's the part founders get wrong more than anything else, and I got it wrong worst of all the first time. Our stories don't fit the script. The officer has a rhythm built around salaried people, where do you work, how long, what's your salary, when are you back.

When you're a founder, half those questions don't have clean answers and the other half he doesn't even know to ask. Do not expect questions like "what's your MRR or how many clients do you have" or "tell me about your co-founder's country of citizenship." So if you wait to be asked the right question, you wait forever, and you walk out with nothing. You have to bring your own story to a window that isn't designed to ask for it. I didn't know that yet. I stood there answering only exactly what he asked, in the fewest words possible, like I was trying not to get caught at something.

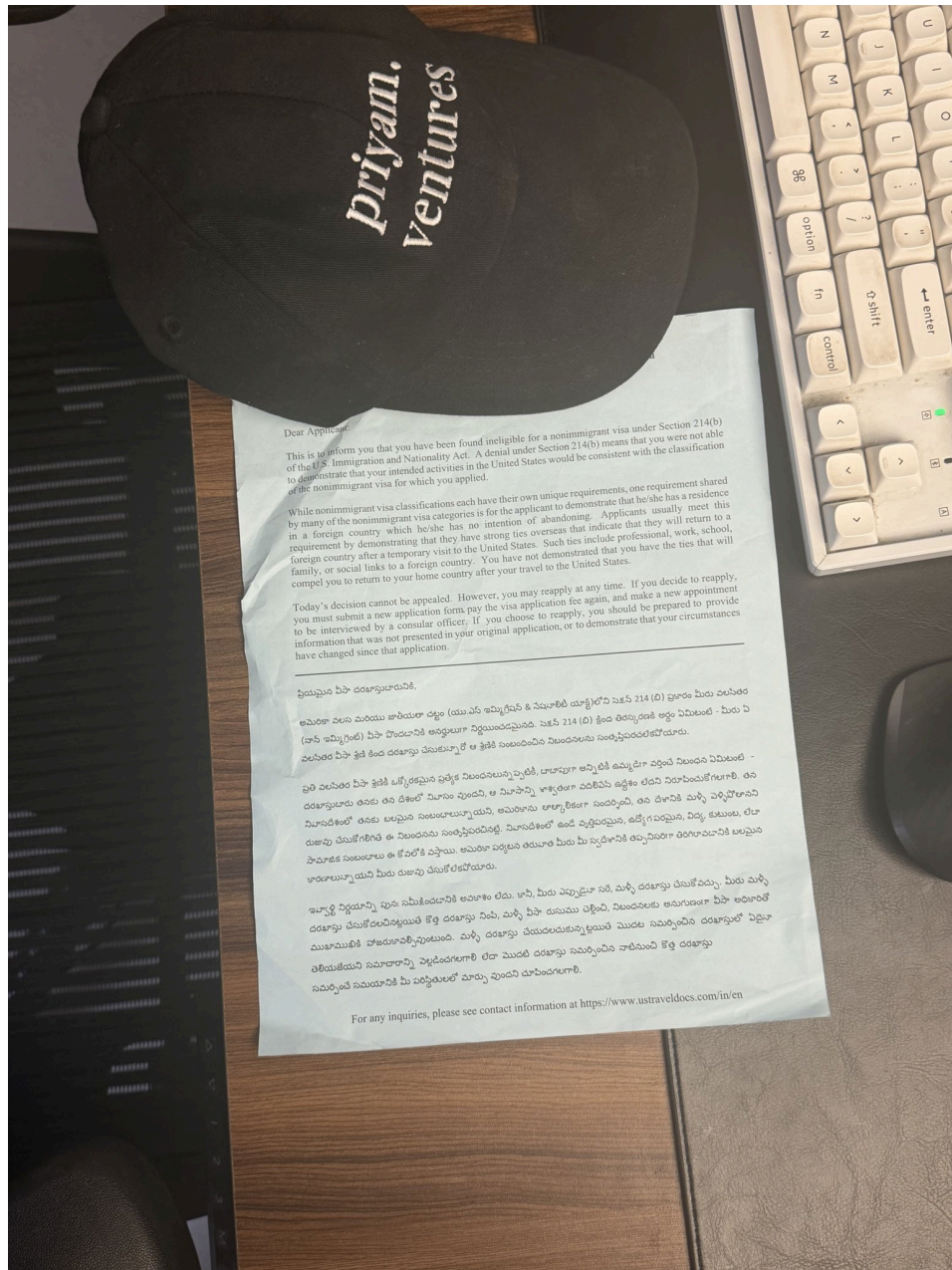
The reason I gave for the trip didn't save me either. It wasn't a clean, single, picture-able thing. It was vague, and vague is fatal, because a vague reason gives the officer nothing to hold and nothing to believe. He's trying to imagine your life, see you going, see you doing the thing, see you coming home. If you hand him fog, he can't see any of it, and when he

can't see it, the answer is no. That's really all a refusal is: he couldn't picture it, so he couldn't approve it.

He asked one question.

I was braced for a second, a third, a whole conversation I'd half-rehearsed. None of it came. He just said they wouldn't be able to issue me a visa this time, that the reasons were printed on the slip he was sliding toward me. Flat, not unkind, already half-turned toward the next person. And then he handed me back my passport.

That's the detail I'd understand the weight of only later. If you're approved, they keep your passport, they have to, that's where the visa goes. They hold onto it and you get it back by courier days later with the stamp inside. So the passport coming back to you across the counter, right there in the moment, is the rejection. The physical book in your hand is the no. I didn't know that yet, so I took it almost gratefully, like he was returning something I'd dropped, and it took a few seconds standing there for it to land that it was over. Then I walked out into the Hyderabad heat holding a passport with nothing new in it and a slip of paper that said 214(b).



I want to be honest about how thin my case actually was, because the gap between that day and the day I got approved is the entire point of this document. I had zero travel history, not a single stamp, no evidence I'd

ever left the country and come back. I had no entity, just my own name typed into a company field. I had no clear reason to go and no clear reason to return. I was dressed like a student.

And I'd answered every question like I was hoping to get away with something rather than like a person with a real life and real reasons to be exactly where he belonged.

Looking back, I genuinely don't blame the officer. I'd given him almost nothing to say yes to. The version of me at that window hadn't earned a yes, and the months between that rejection and my approval were really just me, slowly, expensively, becoming someone the answer could be yes to. And I was able to make that change in only a few months.

The Form Before The Window

Be prepared to back up any statement below with documents, if asked.

After the rejection, I hired a former US visa officer to look at my application.

The rejection slip gave me a code: 214(b). He gave me something more useful. He showed me what my application looked like to the person reading it.

The first time, I had treated the DS-160 like paperwork. I filled the boxes, kept the answers short and assumed the interview would give me time to explain everything properly.

That assumption was wrong.

The DS-160 is like the first interview. It is the only part of your case the officer can read without you standing at the window and a queue forming behind you. Whatever is written there is already on the screen while you are answering questions.

The form and the window have to tell the same truthful story.

Before

In the first application, I had reduced a complicated founder profile to something that barely described me. I put my own name in the company field. The form did not make my business, responsibilities or reason to return easy to picture.

Nothing I wrote was meant to be false. It was simply incomplete in the places where specificity mattered.

After

The officer coached me on how to articulate my own facts clearly; every fact was mine and true. I wrote:

“I know I am young, but I’ve been coding since I was 14 and have developed several successful software products. My current net worth is [redacted]. [...] I’m happy to answer any questions you have.”

The omitted middle described the specific business reason for that specific trip as it existed when I applied. Your reason will be different from mine, so the sentence itself is not the point. The shape is.

One real event. Happening now. A reason a stranger can picture.

For my work, my answer became specific too, in my own words:

“I own a software development company and also a generative AI video venture along with my co-founder. He runs the marketing side of things from Florida and I run the software development side from Bangalore, where I have seven employees. I currently earn about [redacted] per month in profits and have a net worth of [redacted].”

This worked differently from the first version for three reasons.

It pre-empted the obvious doubt. “I know I am young” said the objection out loud before it had time to grow. The answer that followed was not an argument. It was a set of facts.

It used details somebody could picture. A co-founder in one country, me in another, a clear division of work and seven employees in Bangalore. “Seven employees” made the company real faster than a vague claim about being successful ever could.

It invited scrutiny. “I’m happy to answer any questions you have.” Someone hiding a weak story usually tries to end the conversation. A truthful one can survive another question.

The former officer’s instruction mattered as much as the wording:

“Please be prepared to back up any of the statements below with documents, if asked.”

That is the line. Free-text fields exist so you can explain your real situation completely. Using them well is not a trick. Inventing revenue, inflating your role, creating a meeting that does not exist or copying another applicant’s facts crosses the line.

Do not copy my answers. Copy the discipline.

Say what is true. Make it specific. Make the form and the interview the same story. Be ready to prove every sentence.

The Interview That Worked

February 2025. Same consulate, same city, same glass. A completely different person standing in front of it.

I want to walk you through this one slowly, because this is the part you actually came here for. Not the theory, the real thing, what I said, how I said it, and why it landed.

I'd flown into Hyderabad again and checked into the Sheraton right next to the consulate, same as before. I did this on purpose every time. You do not want to be the person sprinting across the city in traffic, sweating, heart going, arriving frazzled for the most important sixty seconds of your year. I wanted to wake up, get dressed slowly, and walk over. Calm is a strategy. Calm is something the officer can see on you before you've said a word.

And the clothes - - blazer, black t-shirt. I've said it already but I'll say it again because it's not vanity, it's a signal. When you walk up looking like a founder, the officer's brain has already started filling in the story in your favor before you open your mouth. You're doing half his work for him. The first time, in a t-shirt, I'd made him work to believe me. This time I wanted belief to be the easy, default reading of me.

He asked where I work. The same question that flattened me six months earlier.

This time I didn't shrink. I told him I run a company with my co-founder, that we make a tool that lets people generate Instagram videos, and that we were in talks to get it acquired. One clean sentence. A real thing, said plainly, with a straight back. And here's the move that matters: I didn't wait for him to know what questions to ask. I already knew he never would. He was never going to say "what's your traction" or "what's your revenue" - - he doesn't think in those terms and he doesn't have time. So I brought the story to him. When there was a beat, a small opening, I filled it myself. I educated him, lightly. This is what we do, this is why we're going, this is who we're meeting. I treated the silence as mine to fill, not his.

That's the single biggest shift from attempt one to attempt two. The first time I answered only what was asked and left everything else unsaid, assuming he'd dig. The second time I understood that nobody was going to dig. Your story only exists in that room if you say it out loud. So I said it.

He asked about the trip. I told him the truth - - a broker in Menlo Park was interested in helping us with the acquisition, and my co-founder and I were going to meet him. Specific. Single. Picture-able.

The officer could see it: two founders, a real meeting, a real reason. Nothing vague for him to trip on.

And the photo. I'd printed a picture from our Dubai trip - - me and my co-founder, clearly together, clearly two people who actually know each other and actually travel. When the relationship came up, I held it up to the glass. It does two things at once. It makes the co-founder real instead

of a name, and it quietly shows the officer that I'm someone who travels abroad and comes back. You're handing him evidence he didn't even ask for, and it's evidence that helps you.

Then came the question that sinks a lot of people: how long are you going for, when are you back. This is where you cannot be vague, and you cannot be dry. Don't just say "two weeks." Give him the picture. I told him I'd be back by the 22nd of March, because my birthday is the 23rd, and my parents were going to be there. All true. And it works because it's specific and it's human -- it's not a date, it's an event, with people in it. The officer isn't checking a calendar. He's imagining your life, and you've just handed him a vivid, believable scene of you coming home to a birthday with your family. That's a person who returns. That's the whole game.

I also mentioned the Indian entity -- Priyam Ventures Private Limited -- naturally, as the thing I run from here, the thing rooted in India that I come back to. One more anchor. One more reason the picture of me leaving and returning makes sense.

And then it was over. He kept my passport.

That's the moment. The first time, he handed it back and I didn't understand what that meant. This time he kept it and I knew.

I knew before he said anything, because the book stayed on his side of the glass. Approved.

Everything I did differently that day came down to one idea: I stopped hoping the officer would understand me and started making sure he could

see me. Clearly, specifically, truthfully. A founder with a real company, real reasons to go, and real reasons - - people, dates, a life to come home to. That's it.

One honest footnote, since this book opens in New York and my reason was Menlo Park. By the time I flew, the acquisition conversation had moved online and the in-person meeting was no longer needed. I still went - - to see my co-founder in Florida and to see the country, which is exactly what a visitor visa is for. A visitor visa doesn't lock you to an itinerary. It locks you to the truth on the day you applied. Mine was true.

The Bill

The visa application fee was only the first charge.

I applied twice. Each application required two separate trips to Hyderabad, one for fingerprints and another for the interview.

That meant four trips in total.

Two fingerprint appointments.

Two interviews.

Flights. Hotels. Local travel. Agent fees. Another application fee after the first refusal.

By the time it was over, I had spent roughly ₹2 lakh.

The money is painful, but the repetition is what stays with you. You prepare, travel, wait, answer a handful of questions and walk away

knowing that the application fee is non-refundable. If the answer is no, the entire sequence starts again.

What It All Came Down To

What follows is the former officer's advice as I understood it, tested against what happened when I applied again. It is not a rule that binds another officer and it is not a promise that the same outcome will follow for somebody else. If you skip the whole story and just want what I actually learned, here it is. Every one of these cost me something to figure out.

Register an Indian entity. This is the big one for us. As young founders and freelancers we don't own land, we don't have houses, we don't have the traditional anchors that prove we're rooted here. A company fixes that. An OPC, an LLP, a Private Limited, it almost doesn't matter which, as long as your name is tied to something that legally exists in India and that you obviously come back to run. The first time, I typed my own name into the company field. The second time, I had Priyam Ventures Private Limited and said it with a straight back. That difference is not small.

Build travel history before you ever apply. An empty passport is the single weakest thing you can hand an officer, because it means he has zero proof you've ever left and come back. My first rejection had zero stamps in it. Before my second attempt I'd been to Dubai, Hungary, France and suddenly my passport was making my case for me before I opened my mouth. Even one clean international trip changes how you're read. Get stamps first.

Have one clear reason to go. Not a vague one. Not a bundle of half-reasons. One specific, single thing the officer can picture in a sentence. Mine was a meeting with a broker in Menlo Park about acquiring our company. The clearer and more specific your reason, the easier it is for him to believe, because a blurry reason gives him nothing to hold, and nothing to hold means no.

Have one clear reason to come back with people and dates in it. This is where most founders go dry, and dry kills you. Don't just say "two weeks." Give him a scene. I told the officer I'd be back by March 22nd because my birthday is the 23rd and my parents were coming. All true. It works because it's specific and it's human, he's not checking a calendar, he's imagining your life, and you've just handed him a vivid picture of you coming home. Real events, real people, real dates.

Dress like the founder you are. I walked for the first time in a t-shirt and made the officer work to take me seriously. The second time, blazer and t-shirt, and belief became the easy default before I'd said a word. This isn't vanity. You're doing half his job for him when you look like the person your story says you are.

Don't rely on your files. I carried a thick stack the first time and not one page was ever looked at. Bring them obviously, sure, keep them ready, but never confuse the paperwork for the case. The case is you, your story, and how clearly and confidently you tell it in sixty seconds. The files mostly stay in your bag.

Fill in your own story, nobody will pull it out of you. The whole interview is built around salaried people. The officer is never going to ask about your revenue, your traction, your product. They don't know, and they don't have time. So if you wait to be asked the right questions, you walk out having said nothing that matters. Find the natural openings and put your story into them yourself. Volunteer it. Make yourself understood instead of hoping to be understood.

Print a photo with your contact in the US. This was the ex-officer's specific trick and it's brilliant. Print a real photo of you with the person you're going to see, a co-founder, a friend, whoever, and hold it up to the glass when the relationship comes up. It does two things at once: it turns a name into a real human, and it quietly proves you're someone who travels and comes back. Evidence he didn't even ask for, working in your favor.

Keep the first trip short and easy to describe. Plan two weeks, not two months. A long stay invites a fair question, and it is one you should be able to answer before you ever book. If you are not working, and you are not allowed to, how are you funding two months in America, and what are you doing there the whole time? Sometimes there is a perfectly good answer. Often there is not one yet, and that is a sign the trip is not ready. A short trip with one clear reason is easier to plan, easier to explain and easier to believe. Keep it simple.

Never lie. About anything. I've said this already and I'll say it again because it sits underneath every other rule on this page. Everything that worked for me worked because it was true. These aren't tricks for dressing up a false story, they're ways of telling a true one well. Getting caught in a

lie doesn't just cost you this visa, it can cost you every future one. There is no version of this where lying is the smart move. Tell the truth, and tell it clearly.

What You Cannot Do On This Visa

This part matters more than people think, because getting it wrong doesn't just risk one trip, it can affect every future one. So let me be plain about what a B1/B2 actually is and isn't.

A B1/B2 is a visitor visa. The B1 side is for business activities - - meetings, conferences, negotiations, talking to a potential partner or acquirer, the kind of thing I applied for.

The B2 side is for tourism, visiting friends, family, and leisure. Most founders and freelancers end up doing a mix of both, and that's completely normal. Meetings and fun on the same trip is fine.

Here's the line you cannot cross: you cannot work. And I mean specifically that you cannot do your actual job for money while you're there. A lot of people have this idea that because their work is just a laptop, they can fly to the US on this visa, open that laptop in a café in San Francisco, keep

shipping, keep billing clients, keep running operations, and that it doesn't count because nobody can see it. That is not allowed. It doesn't matter that the work is remote or that your clients aren't American. Doing your income-earning work on US soil on a visitor visa is working, and working is not what this visa is for.

So what can you actually do? If you're there on the business side, you can take meetings, sit in on negotiations, attend a conference, scope a deal. What you can't do is sit down and perform the labor of your business for income. And if you're there on the leisure side, you're a tourist - - you're seeing the country, seeing people, having a good time, and that's the whole job.

This is also why your first trip should be a short one, easier to plan, easier to explain, easier to believe. Keep it simple.

A short trip with one clear reason is easier to plan, easier to explain, and easier to believe. Keep it simple.

None of this is meant to scare you. It's meant to keep you safe. The whole point of doing this honestly is that you get a ten-year visa and you get to keep coming back for a decade without ever once having to worry. Respect what the visa is for, don't try to quietly bend it into something it isn't, and it'll serve you for years. Try to game it, and you risk the whole thing.

Appendix: What to Carry, and a Few Last Words

What to actually bring

You may never be asked for any of this. Bring it anyway, because the one time you need it and don't have it is the time it matters and because having it makes you calmer walking in. Calm is the real reason to carry it.

Your passport, current and any old ones with previous travel stamps. The DS-160 confirmation page. Your interview appointment letter. The visa fee payment receipt. A photo as per the spec. If you have an Indian entity - - and you should, carry your incorporation documents, and anything that

shows it's real and active. Bank statements and proof of funds. Anything that supports your stated reason for the trip: an invitation, an email thread, a meeting confirmation, whatever makes your one clear reason tangible. And the printed photo of you with the person you're going to see, kept somewhere you can reach it fast.

That's it. You don't need a binder. You need the right few things and the confidence that you have them.

The DS-160, briefly

I won't walk you through the form field by field, because the form changes and because I'm telling you about my experience, not filling yours out for you. But two things from my own application are worth saying plainly. First, the company field, if you have an entity, put the entity, not your own name. My own name in that field the first time was a quiet signal that I wasn't anchored to anything, and I didn't even realize I was sending it. Second, whatever you write on the form has to match what you say at the window, exactly. The officer has your answers in front of him. If your mouth says something different from your form, that gap is the thing that sinks you. Fill it out as the truth, and then tell the same truth out loud.

A few honest words before you go

I need to be clear about what this document is and isn't.

I am not a lawyer. I am not an immigration consultant or agent. Nothing in here is legal advice. This is one founder's account of what happened to him across two visa attempts, what I did, what I changed, what I was told, and what worked for me. That's all it is, and that's all I'd ever want it to be.

What worked for me may not work for you, because your situation is yours and the decision is never mine to give. Every visa decision rests entirely with the consular officer, under their own judgment, and nobody - - not me, not any consultant charging you lakhs, not anyone -- can guarantee you an approval. Anyone who tells you they can guarantee a visa is lying to you, and you should walk away from them and keep your money.

And the one thing I'd leave you with above everything else: tell the truth. Every single technique in this document is a way of presenting a true situation clearly and confidently. None of it is a way to dress up something false. The officers are good at their jobs. Lies surface, and when they do, the cost isn't just this trip, it can be every future one, permanently. I got my visa by being honest, well-prepared, and clear about who I actually am. That's the whole method. There isn't a shortcut underneath it.

Be honest, be prepared, look like the person your story says you are, and give the officer a life he can easily picture you coming home to. That's everything I know.

This is a personal account and general educational material. I am not a lawyer, immigration consultant or representative of the United States government. Nothing here guarantees a visa, predicts how an officer will decide or replaces advice from a qualified professional who has reviewed

your complete circumstances. A visa decision is individual. The only rule I would carry into every application is simpler than any script: tell the truth completely, keep the form and the interview consistent, and be prepared to support what you say. Good luck. I hope it goes your way, and I hope this saved you some of what it cost me to learn.

Don't forget to treat yourself with some great Biryani in Hyderabad if that's your consulate too.



Godspeed.